the end of primary school.[15] At the other end of the education continuum, at the tertiary level, India has an even longer way to go. India's gross enrollment ratio – the proportion of Indians between the age of eighteen and twenty-three who go to college – is only 27 per cent. The figure for China is 49 per cent.[16]

When they get to college, Indians will find the quality of their education compares badly with that of their Chinese counterparts. The Times Higher Education (THE) rankings of the top 100 universities in the world indicates that in 2019 India had no universities and China had three in the elite group. In the Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) rankings of top universities in 2019, India had none while China had six in the top 100. Between 2014 and 2019, India remained at none; China on the other hand went from three to six universities. A more refined search of the QS rankings that focuses on the top 300 world universities shows that in 2019 India had six and China had twelve universities. Among the top 300 Asian universities, India improved to a count of thirty-nine whereas China had seventy-three.[17] In the QS 2021 rankings, India's highest ranked university was the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay, which came in 172nd. China's highest ranked university was Tsinghua University, which came in at 15th.[18]

What about India's and China's health profiles? Three indicators are key from the point of view of the number of able adults who can work more or less efficiently and whose cognitive abilities have developed normally: the extent of undernourishment; the extent of stunting; and the extent of wasting (acute malnutrition). A comparison between India and China shows once again that India does badly. In terms of the percentage of the population that is undernourished, the most recent figures (2017–19) indicate that India had 14 per cent and China had less than 2.5 per cent. The prevalence of wasting among Indian children below the age of five in 2015–19 was 17.3 per cent whereas among Chinese children it was 2 per cent. As for the prevalence of stunting among Indian children below the age of five in 2015–19, it was 34.7 per cent for India and 5.5 per cent for China.[19]

Speaking to a group of Indian administrators, I once made the point that Indians were among the shortest people on average in the world and had